For, this matter will (be made by me to) progress, and will (be made to) progress considerably; it will (be made to) progress to at least one and a half.

And cause ye matter to be engraved on rocks where an occasion presents itself.

And (wherever) there are stone pillars here, it must be caused to be engraved on stone pillars.

And according to the letter of this (proclamation) (You) must dispatch (an officer) everywhere, as far as your district (extends).

(This) proclamation was issued by (me) on tour.

256 (nights) (had then been) spent on tour.[19]

This first edict of Ashoka is also among his shortest. It is not part of a set of several edicts, as are those inscribed in later years. The personal glimpse of the emperor's inner life is linked to a range of pronouncements about his mission. The message is partly confessional, presenting his self-realization and organizing it in terms of a chronological pattern of development. The text was dispatched by a ruler in the midst of a long tour, it having been surmised that the presence of the number 256 in all versions of this message indicates the number of days (or nights) that Ashoka had been away from the royal capital, Pataliputra. The 'date' also shows that all of these were dispatched more or less simultaneously.[20]

Perhaps because it captures an important moment in the life of Ashoka from the time he converted to Buddhism, the brevity and crowding are understandable. They betray an impatience in wanting to share what the metamorphosis meant for him as a ruler, and therefore ought to mean for his empire at large. There were good political reasons as well for sharing the information, inasmuch as it made it simpler to expect his subjects to try and emulate him if they understood the context within which his transformation had happened. Let us try and understand the information and instructions contained in this imperial message and see how they are interlinked.

Ashoka made grassroots contact with his people only after he became a Buddhist, there being no epigraphs showing this kind of intent for his pre-Buddhist phase. He appeared as a charged-up Buddhist ruler across a large